remind Bairam of how he'd often 'said . . . that it was time we dealt with affairs of state'.[56] Was Bairam's impatience exacerbated by paranoia, the fears of a Shia Turcoman who had imprisoned a Sunni rival, Abul Ma'ali, and executed a Chagatai nobleman, Tardi Beg? Bairam had every reason to believe that the Chagatai nobility mistrusted him. Munim Khan, Akbar's ataliq not long ago, was escorting the harem to Hindustan when he heard what Bairam had done to Tardi Beg. Promptly, the cautious khan turned back around. Was Bairam really contemplating a further purge of Akbar's court? If so, he must have known that his plan would require the young padishah's deference, and that deference was not Akbar's strong suit.

And what of Akbar? How would he have felt being told off by his regent for a bit of hijinks with elephants?

'At this time a strange thing happened,' writes Abul Fazl. Akbar, who had once put men in dog leashes for their slackness, 'began to chafe' until his indignation 'broke out into anger'. Shouting let no one dare follow him, not even his 'grooms and such like persons', he got on his best horse, Hayran, unequalled for speed, and galloped away.

After a while, Akbar got off, but Hayran, wild and 'fiery' like his rider, continued to run, until he was out of sight. Akbar was entirely alone, not even the impatient whinnying of a horse to distract him. Maybe this is what he wanted. A moment away from the unending drumroll of events that had filled his life since Humayun died, a moment away from Bairam's nagging annoyance and Maham's solicitous advice. Abul Fazl says that Akbar prayed, 'communing with his God'.

Time passed. Having left the camp of annoying adults in a rage, Akbar may have begun to wish he hadn't. Especially now that he had no horse to return upon, Hayran having disappeared across the horizon. He was wondering what to do, beginning to worry, maybe, in his helpless, unaccustomed solitude. Just then, Hayran returned, galloping to Akbar from wherever it is he'd gone to douse his own fury, and coming to a tame halt by his young rider's side. Akbar 'mounted the noble animal', astonished – an astonishment that he must have communicated to his historian, years later, for Abul Fazl's description of the scene is rather more overwrought ('to noble discourse of this kind there is no limit!') than the reunion warrants.